him, washed, shaved, shod, dressed and buttoned from top to toe, on the threshold of his office. The day's work was going to begin.

Francis Bennett went on into the reporters' room. His fifteen hundred reporters, placed before an equal number of telephones, were passing on to subscribers the news which had come in during the night from the four quarters of the earth. In addition to his telephone, each reporter has in front of him a series of commutators, which allow him to get into communication with this or that telephotic line.

Thus the subscribers have not only the story but the sight of these events.

Francis Bennett questioned one of the ten astronomical reporters – a service which was growing because of the recent discoveries in the stellar world.

'Well, Cash, what have you got?'

'Phototelegrams from Mercury, Venus and Mars, Sir.'

'Interesting! And Jupiter?'

'Nothing so far! We haven't been able to understand the signals the Jovians make. Perhaps ours haven't reached them? ….'

'Aren't you getting some result from the moon, at any rate?'

'Not yet, Mr Bennett.'

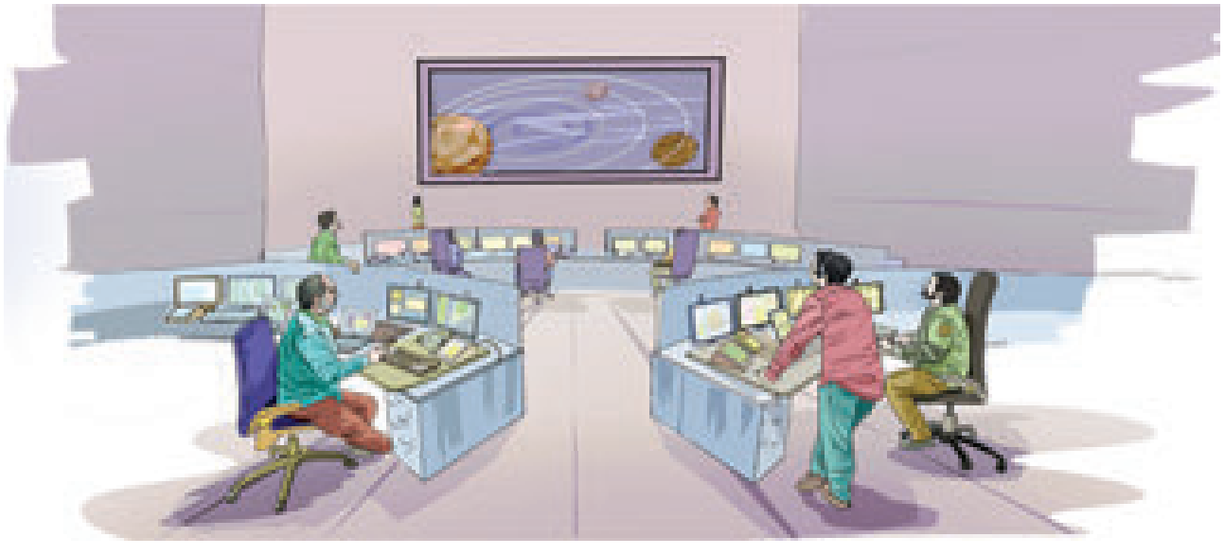
'Well, this time, you can't blame optical science! The moon is six hundred times nearer than Mars, and yet our correspondence service is in regular operation with Mars. It can't be telescopes we need…'

'No, it's the inhabitants,' Corley replied.

'You dare tell me that the moon is uninhabited?'

'On the face it turns towards us, at any rate, Mr Bennett. Who knows whether on the other side…'

'Well, there's a very simple method of finding out.'



10th English_Book.indb 154 26-02-2019 16:25:07